HACKATHON PROPOSAL

FinHacks: Ecobank Campus Innovation Challenge 26

OVERVIEW

The Ecobank Campus Innovation Challenge 2026 is a multi-university hackathon designed to engage 500 students across 5 universities in Nigeria in solving real-world financial and banking challenges.

The event aims to drive innovation, financial inclusion, and youth engagement, while encouraging participants to onboard into the Ecobank ecosystem.

RESEARCH ON YOUTHS WITH ONLINE BANKING EXPERIENCE

A significant proportion of young Africans remain unbanked, with studies showing youth are less likely than adults to own bank accounts. In some regions, up to 77% of youth remain financially excluded. This presents a major opportunity for banks like Ecobank to drive youth financial inclusion.

1. **Youth Banking Penetration in Africa (General, Not Ecobank)**
    a. Young Africans are less likely to have bank accounts than adults
    b. This is a widely cited finding (World Bank & Ecobank partnership data).
2. **Large Portion of Youth Are Still Unbanked**

    Example (Ecobank program data):

    a. In The Gambia 77% of youth are financially excluded (unbanked).
    b. Meaning only about 23% of youth have ANY bank account (across all banks, not just Ecobank).

3. **Ecobank's Own Youth Initiatives (Indirect Evidence)**

   Ecobank plus Junior Achievement program aims to reach 600,000 plus young people with financial literacy.

   This shows:

   a. Youth banking adoption is still developing
   b. Banks are actively trying to increase penetration

OBJECTIVES

Primary Objectives

1. Increase youth adoption of Ecobank accounts (CASA)
2. Drive minimum ₦5,000 deposits per participant
3. Promote financial literacy and digital banking adoption

Secondary Objectives

1. Identify innovative solutions in:
   a. Customer Satisfaction
   b. Youth CASA Growth
   c. Return on Investment (ROI)
2. Strengthen Ecobank's brand presence among students
3. Build long-term relationships with future professionals

TARGET AUDIENCE

1. Students from 5 selected universities
   a. A fair power pull between Private and Federal universities in the field of technology.
   b. Top 3 federal universities and top 2 private universities in Nigeria tech space.
2. Total Participants: 500 students, a minimum of 5 and maximum 7 from each team.
3. Field: Technology

HACKATHON THEMES

Participants will build solutions around:

1. **Customer Satisfaction**
    a. Improving digital banking experience
    b. Reducing transaction friction
    c. Enhancing customer support
2. **Youth CASA (Current Account Savings Account)**
    a. Strategies to attract and retain young customers
    b. Gamified savings and spending tools
    c. Student-focused financial products
3. **Return on Investment (ROI)**
    a. Increasing profitability from youth accounts
    b. Smart financial analytics
    c. Cost-effective banking strategies

PARTICIPATION REQUIREMENT (STRATEGIC ENGAGEMENT MODEL)

To participate fully in the hackathon, students will:

1. Open an Ecobank account : This is where all rewards for participating will be sent.
2. Deposit a minimum of ₦5,000 to make it an active account for easy reward process.
3. Receive:
    a. Welcome pack
    b. Hackathon access
    c. Certification
    d. Eligibility for prizes

INCENTIVE STRATEGY

To encourage participation:

1. Cash prizes for winners

2. Free data / airtime rewards
3. Certificates of participation
4. Internship opportunities with Ecobank
5. Exclusive rewards for active users

EVENT SCHEDULE

Phase 1: Pre-Event (2–3 Weeks Before)

1. University outreach & promotions
2. Campus ambassadors onboarding
3. Account registration drive
4. Awareness campaigns (social media, flyers, webinars)

Phase 2: Registration & Onboarding (1 Week)

1. Student registration portal launch
2. Ecobank account setup booths (physical & online)
3. Deposit confirmation (₦5,000 minimum)
4. Team formation (5–7 members per team)

Phase 3: Hackathon Week (Main Event 1 day)

Day One (Opening and Ideation)

1. Opening ceremony (Ecobank keynote)
2. Problem statement briefing
3. Team brainstorming
4. Mentorship sessions

Day Two (Development)

1. Product design & development
2. Technical and business mentorship
3. Midway progress review

Day Three (Pitch & Judging)

1. Final solution submission
2. Pitch presentations
3. Judging & evaluation
4. Award ceremony

JUDGING CRITERIA

1. Innovation & Creativity
2. Feasibility & Scalability
3. Business Value (ROI impact)
4. User Experience (Customer Satisfaction)
5. Alignment with Ecobank Goals

MARKETING AND ENGAGEMENT STRATEGY

1. Campus ambassadors program
2. Social media campaigns
3. Influencer/student leader partnerships
4. Email campaigns & webinars
5. On-campus activation booths

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

1. Approximately 3,000 plus new Ecobank accounts
2. Minimum ₦15 Million total deposits
3. Increased youth engagement
4. Innovative fintech solutions for Ecobank

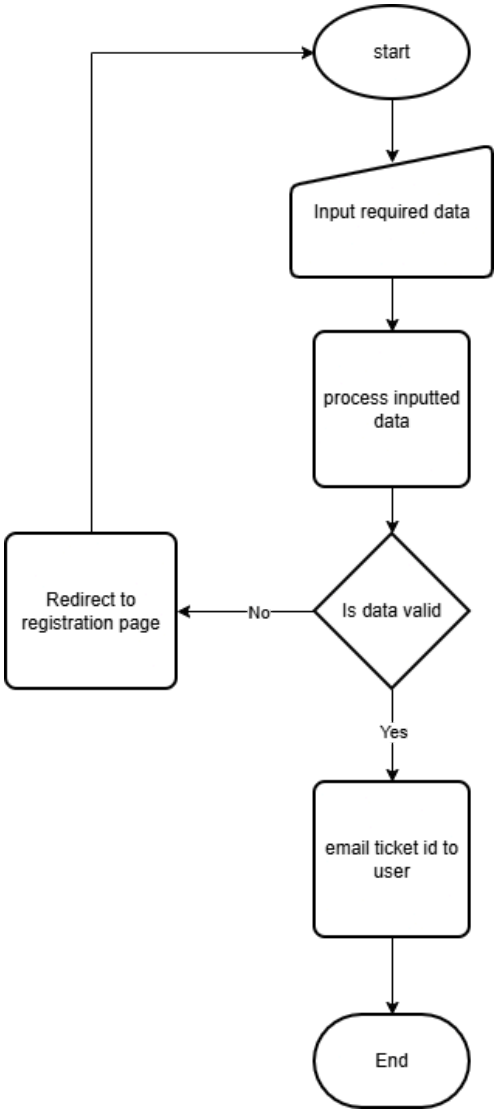
SPONSORSHIP VALUE FOR ECOBANK

1. Direct access to an average of 3000 plus young customers
2. Brand positioning as a youth-focused digital bank
3. Pipeline for future talent recruitment

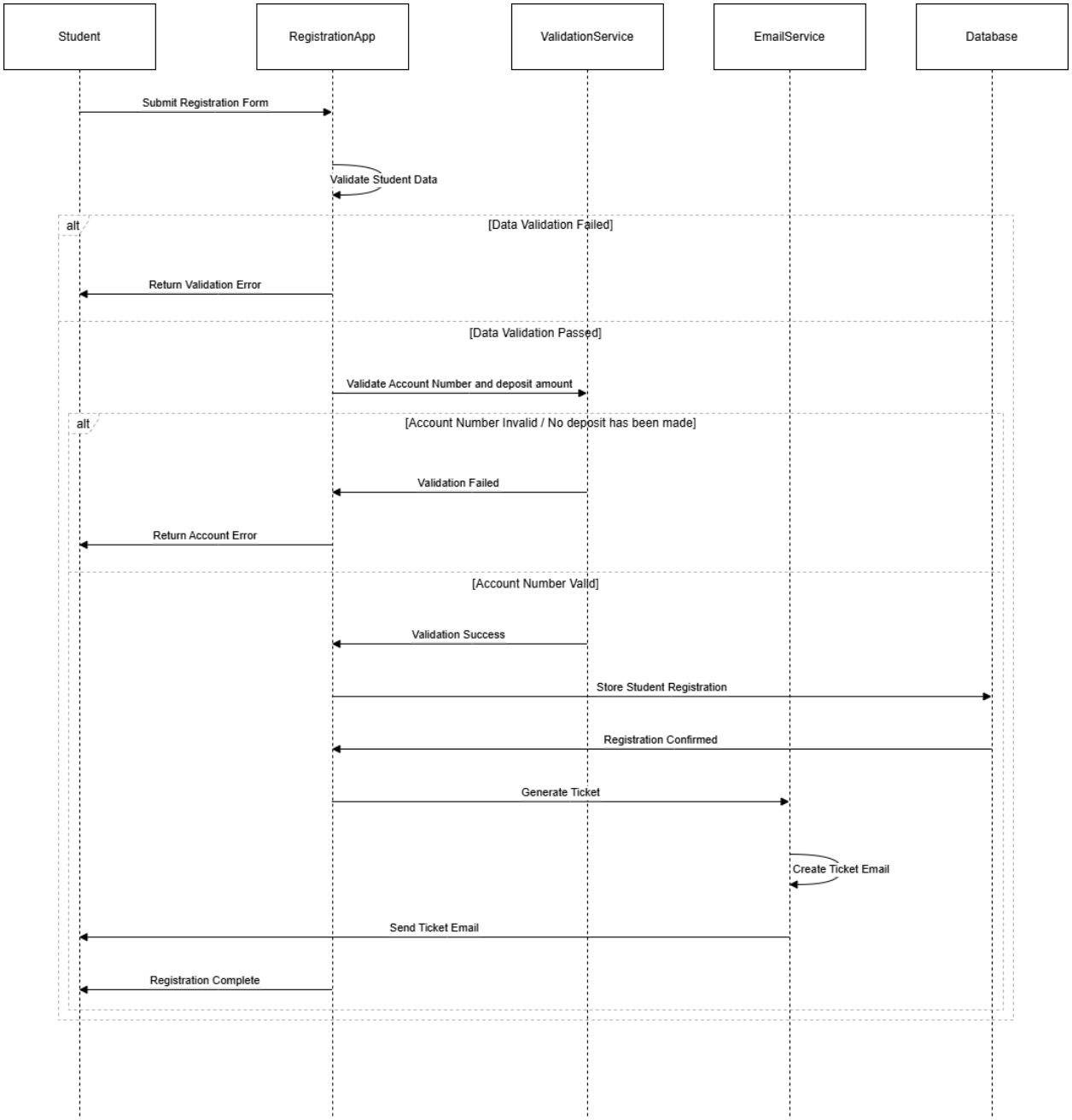
4. Data-driven insights from student solutions

PARTICIPANT ONBOARDING PROCESS

The process will require a simple web application that will receive participant required data and validate it. The process of validation will also include verifying the user's Ecobank account number and their available balance (minimum of 5000 naira deposit). Flow chart and High level architecture diagram of the registration app is below.



Flow chart of the registration app



High level architecture of the registration app

CONCLUSION

The Ecobank Campus Innovation Challenge is more than a hackathon. It is a strategic youth engagement and financial inclusion initiative that combines innovation, education, and business growth.

This initiative will position Ecobank as a leader in youth banking and digital transformation in Nigeria.

REFERENCES

Junior Achievement Africa - Ecobank foundation

Group Chairman's Sustainability Award 2023 (Ecobank)